



THE LITERARY SCIENTIST

A Multi-Disciplinary Journal for Literature and Science

ISSN: 3048-7366(Online)

<https://theliteraryscientist.org/>

Volume 1

Issue 2

09.02.2025

Paper Title:

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COMIC *MENSTRUPEDIA***

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MENSTRUAL EDUCATION THROUGH INDIAN INFO COMIC

MENSTRUPEDIA

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Abstract

The paper is about menstrual education through the Indian info comic Menstrupedia, focusing on breaking taboos, promoting menstrual hygiene, and empowering young girls and women. This paper discusses the importance of menstrual education through comics, specifically focusing on the Menstrupedia Comic created by Aditi Gupta and Tuhin Paul. The comic aims to demystify menstruation, reduce stigma, and educate young readers about puberty's physical and emotional aspects. It is divided into four chapters covering puberty, the menstrual cycle, tracking periods, and menstrual hygiene management. Menstrupedia uses a multimodal approach combining visuals and narrative to break social stereotypes and provide scientific information engagingly. The comic is available in 17 languages and co-published in 11 countries. It collaborates with organizations and campaigns to promote menstrual health and hygiene, addressing cultural taboos and misinformation. The paper highlights the effectiveness of comics in increasing awareness, promoting healthy practices, and fostering empathy, making them a valuable tool in menstrual health education.

Keywords: Menstrual Education, Hygiene, Puberty, Menstrupedia, Menstrual Health Awareness.

Introduction

In recent years, the topic of menstruation education through comics has received a lot of attention, especially in children's and young adult literature. This method seeks to demystify menstruation, decrease stigma, and educate young readers with sympathetic stories about the physical and emotional components of puberty.

Menstrual hygiene management, as defined by the WHO/UNICEF Joint Monitoring Programme 2012, is:

“Women and adolescent girls are using a clean menstrual management material to absorb or collect menstrual blood, that can be changed in privacy as often as necessary, using soap and water for washing the body as required, and having access to safe and convenient facilities to dispose of used menstrual management materials. They understand the basic facts linked to the menstrual cycle and how to manage it with dignity and without discomfort or fear.”

Menstruation can be perplexing and even scary. Girls may feel ashamed or uneasy while expressing it. However, there is nothing to be embarrassed about; it is simply a normal part of life. The more women understand menstruation hygiene, the better they will be able to take care of themselves and stay healthy.

The lack of means for hygienic management of menstruation can cause discomfort and psychological stress and adds to the shame and sometimes depression that women and girls

experience because of menstruation-related taboos and stigma (Sweetman and Medland 2017). Promoting menstrual health and cleanliness is a vital way to protect women's dignity, privacy, physical integrity, and, as a result, self-efficacy.

24% of girls miss one or more school days during menstruation. (Source: British Medical Journal). Girls learn to live with the agony and fear of periods from a young age, and they rarely seek treatment when they are in physical or mental anguish as a result of the stigma associated with the topic. Silence, exclusion, taunting, and humiliation have a negative impact on the girls' psychological and physical development and significantly limit their potential. Lack of access to basic hygienic facilities and awareness leads to an increase in dropouts.

Significance of Menstrual Education

Insufficient information on health topics can impact both individual and societal well-being and growth. The Indian government has created menstrual hygiene management standards to address limited norms and knowledge. These guidelines prioritize education, awareness at all levels (individual, family, and society), and skilled support for the issue. Non-Governmental Organizations like Sachhi Saheli, TARSHI, and Vikalp Design generate instructional content and hold frequent awareness campaigns and workshops. Companies marketing menstrual hygiene products have developed advertisements and programs (e.g., Stayfree's Women for Change and Whisper's Touch the Pickle), and a Bollywood film was released about Arunachalam Muruganantham, the Pad Man of India.

Menstrual hygiene education is critical for empowering people, especially young girls and women, by providing accurate information about the natural biological process of

menstruation. Learning about the physiological changes that occur during menstruation can help to reduce anxiety, misunderstanding, and misconceptions about the topic. Educating people about menstrual health and hygiene practices allows them to make more informed decisions about their bodies and well-being. This understanding enables people to efficiently regulate their menstrual periods, boosting confidence and self-esteem.

CRY (Child Rights and You) India recognizes the detrimental impact of shame, stigma, and misinformation surrounding menstruation on young girls and women. The organisation aims to break the silence around periods and initiate open conversations about menstruation through its 'Let's Talk About Periods' campaign.

Sociocultural norms in India hinder free discussion of MHE, highlighting a pressing need for improvement. Indian women face myths, superstitions, and limitations regarding menstruation and health, regardless of age. In 2015, the Indian government adopted national Menstrual Hygiene Management (MHM) standards as part of the Swachh Bharat (Clean India) Mission. To encourage menstrual hygiene, state governments are putting sanitary pad vending machines in schools and other places.

An Overview of *Menstrupedia*

Comics have been shown to be an effective medium for breaking taboos around periods and starting discussions about them. One noteworthy example that has played a significant role in raising period awareness and encouraging healthy habits among young girls in India is the *Menstrupedia* Comic, which was created by Aditi Gupta and Tuhin Paul over a period of 18 months starting March 2013. Social stereotypes and patriarchal views about menstruation are successfully shattered by the comic's multimodal approach, which

combines visual components with an understandable narrative. *Menstrupedia* works to dispel the stigma and silence around menstruation by presenting scientific data in an interesting way.

Menstrupedia is a social venture that offers an instructional reference on menstruation health through several media platforms, including a website, comic, YouTube channel, and Facebook page. The website includes a fast guide to menstruation, a blog, and a Q&A forum. *Menstrupedia* was created to help young and old Indian women manage their menstrual health. *Menstrupedia* comics are accessible in 17 languages and co-published in 11 countries, including Kenya, the United Kingdom, Malaysia, Brazil, Egypt, Australia, the Maldives, Uruguay, Nepal, Hungary, and Zimbabwe.

The *Menstrupedia* comic was created in collaboration with the sanitary pad manufacturer Stay Free. This 88-page comic is divided into four chapters: growing up (puberty-related changes in male and female bodies), and understanding periods. When is my next period? Learn about menstrual tracking and period care, including myths, hygiene, and management. The comic is intended for girls aged nine and up, but the website suggests it can also be enjoyed by younger or older females, as well as guys.

A Precis of *Menstrupedia* Comic

In the opening chapter, "Growing Up," Gupta introduces readers to the characters Priya, Pinki, Jiya, and Mira and explores the changes that girls go through during puberty. Then, in the second chapter, "What Are Periods," Gupta discusses the menstrual cycle and its significance in human reproduction. In the third chapter, "When is My Next Period," Gupta discusses how to track menstrual cycles as well as the symptoms of premenstrual

syndrome, that implies physical and emotional changes in a girl's body in the days preceding her monthly cycle. Finally, in the fourth chapter, "Taking Care During the Period," Gupta instructs girls how to use sanitary pads and maintain good cleanliness during their menstrual periods.

Gupta presents the reader with *Menstrupedia* Comic's primary characters in the first chapter, "Growing Up," and discusses the mental and physical changes that females may go through during puberty. Three girls, Pinki, Jiya, and Mira, celebrate Pinki's ninth birthday celebration in her house at the start of the comic while they wait for Priya to show up. Pinki's elder sister, Priya, is a physician. Priya tells Pinki that she can't wait to watch her grow up when she gets to the party. Priya tells the girls about puberty, which she says happens between the ages of eight and thirteen, in response to Jiya's queries about why individuals grow up and what causes them to mature.

The pituitary gland, a pea-shaped gland located at the lower end of the brain that produces hormones—substances that control body processes like menstruation—is what Priya explains to the girls. People grow as a result of those hormones being released into the body. Then, Priya tells the girls about the bodily changes that come with puberty. These bodily changes include height gain, the development of breasts, the emergence of acne on the skin, and the growth of hair in the genital and underarm areas. Priya also discusses the emotional shifts that females go through during adolescence, including romantic feelings for other people.

In the first chapter, Jiya also goes through her first menstruation. Jiya feels damp in her underpants and excuses herself to use the restroom at the party. Jiya finds blood in her

underpants as she is in the bathroom. Jiya, confused and terrified, summons Pinki to her rescue. Pinki is perplexed as to how Jiya bled in her underpants and urges Jiya to seek assistance from Priya, as she is a doctor. Pinki informs Priya of Jiya's dilemma, and Priya reassures Pinki that the blood in Jiya's underwear is simply her period, before giving Jiya a sanitary pad. The following day, Priya returns to Pinki's home to educate Pinki, Jiya, and Mira about menstruation.

In the second chapter of *Menstrupedia* Comic, "What Are Periods," Gupta utilizes Priya's character to illustrate the relationship between menstruation and human reproduction. The book includes drawings of Priya describing to the girls that periods are three to seven days long and occur once a month. She then discusses menstruation as a crucial milestone in pregnancy. Then, Priya adds that what she refers to as babies, which are formally known as embryos or fetuses until birth, develop in the uterus, which is located in the lower abdomen of the body.

Priya shows a diagram of a uterus. Priya uses the diagram to demonstrate that the uterus has two ovaries attached on either side, each of which carries egg cells. Priya explains that one egg cell is discharged from one of the woman's ovaries each month, and if the egg cell gets into contact with a male sperm cell, the two cells join to form an embryo. Priya discusses how the embryo develops into a fetus within the uterus.

In the second chapter, Gupta uses Priya's character to convey the concept of menstruation. Illustrations accompany Priya's narration to assist girls understand how menstruation occurs in the body. First, Priya explains that each month, the pituitary gland produces a hormone that causes the ovaries to release an egg cell, a process known as

ovulation. She explains to the girls that ovulation occurs solely in the female body. Priya then describes how the egg cell enters the uterus via the fallopian tube, a biological structure linking the ovaries to the uterus. Priya goes on to explain that the uterus prepares for the potential of pregnancy by producing a soft tissue lining packed with blood inside the uterus. If an embryo is produced when an egg cell meets a sperm cell, the uterine soft tissue lining offers nutrition for the embryo to grow into a fetus. Priya says that if the egg cell does not come into contact with a sperm cell, the soft tissue lining and blood are shed and evacuated through the vagina, a process known as menstruation or a period. In line with Priya, menstruation occurs once a month, but cycles might vary in length amongst girls. Priya also informs the girls that their menstrual cycles may be inconsistent at first as their bodies adjust. A brightly colored, yellow box is featured in the book, advising females to seek medical treatment if their menstrual cycle pauses for more than ninety days after being regular, as this could indicate issues within the body.

In addition, in the second part of *Menstrupedia* Comic, Gupta uses Priya's persona to highlight common menstrual symptoms for girls. Priya explains that stomach discomfort is one of the most prevalent menstrual symptoms. Priya, on the other hand, debunks a widely held notion in Hindu culture about menstruation, claiming that the loss of blood during menstruation leads women to feel excessively exhausted. Priya explains that the amount of blood lost by girls during menstruation is quite little, perhaps two teaspoons, making acute exhaustion unlikely. Another yellow box appears in the book, instructing girls to seek medical assistance if their menstrual cycles are heavy and require them to change their sanitary pads every hour.

In the third chapter, "When is My Next Period," Gupta explains how to track menstrual

cycles and PMS symptoms. Premenstrual Syndrome is a wide range of symptoms that girls and women can encounter in the days running up to their menstruation. Priya says that if a girl's menstrual cycle is regular, she can determine the date of her next period by adding the day of her last period to the length of her typical menstrual cycle. Priya explains that if a girl has PMS symptoms, she may be able to predict when her next period will arrive. The book illustrates the numerous physical and emotional symptoms linked with premenstrual syndrome, such as acne, headaches, abdominal pains, and mood changes.

Menstrual hygiene management is explained by Gupta through Priya's character in the last segment of *Menstrupedia* Comic, "Taking Care During Period." Priya first shows how a girl might collect menstrual blood by inserting a disposable sanitary pad inside her underpants. Then, roughly every six hours, she tells the girls to change and discard the sanitary pad. Second, Priya shows the girls how to use a cloth pad, which is similar to a sanitary pad but can be used again and again if they wash it after each usage. Third, Priya describes how a girl who cannot afford or obtain a cloth or sanitary pad might make one at home.

Priya also discusses what a girl should do if she is unprepared for her first period at school. Instead of skipping school, Priya advises girls to talk to their parents, female instructors, or school nurses about their menstrual periods. Priya is asked by Jiya what would happen if she felt self-conscious about getting her period. Priya responds that most girls have menstruation and that there is no reason to feel embarrassed about it. Several hygienic routines, including taking a daily shower, wearing clean underwear, and changing sanitary pads on a regular basis, are illustrated throughout the last chapter.

Finally, near the end of the fourth chapter, Gupta discusses the myths and stigmas surrounding menstruation. One of the girls, Mira, inquires whether it is true that girls should not join religious organizations, pray, or touch sacred things during their menstrual periods, citing a cultural notion that menstruation makes a woman impure or dirty. Priya says that menstruation is a natural human phenomenon with nothing dirty about it. Mira responds positively, indicating that she is no longer embarrassed about her menstruation as a result of her conversation with Priya. Following its publication, *Menstrupedia* Comic impacted individuals and groups to confront misconceptions and a lack of education about menstruation in India.

The Crucial Function of *Menstrupedia* Comic in Menstrual Health Education

“Menstrupedia made it okay to talk about menstruation, and that is quite empowering for many people.”

- Aditi Gupta, co-founder of Menstrupedia.

The societal misconceptions and taboos around menstruation have been dismantled in a significant manner through comics like *Menstrupedia*. They make the subject stigma-free and more approachable by using a multi-modal, visually appealing, and narrative-driven approach. This facilitates bringing up the topic of menstruation, which frequently remains taboo, particularly in conservative cultures.

Comics have also been utilized successfully in participatory workshops to promote menstrual hygiene management. Adolescent females in Rajasthan, India, were asked to create and share their own comics about menstruation for the study. This participatory

approach not only boosted their awareness of menstrual hygiene, but also served as a forum for discussing societal taboos and asking questions regarding the biological process. The use of comics in this context served to raise consciousness and comprehension of menstrual health.

Comics can effectively increase understanding about menstruation and menstrual hygiene, according to studies. For instance, a workshop using *Grassroots* comic in Rajasthan, India, greatly boosted the awareness of adolescent girls on menstrual hygiene and helped them discuss societal taboos and ask questions about menstruation. Similarly, the Yogyakarta study discovered that comics were more successful than pamphlets at educating primary school pupils about menarche and menstruation.

According to research, comic books are more successful than standard instructional resources in increasing understanding about menarche and menstruation. A quasi-experimental study conducted in Yogyakarta, Indonesia, examined the efficiency of comic books with leaflets as learning tools. The findings revealed that comics were much more successful in increasing knowledge scores among elementary school students. This implies that the engaging and relatable format of comics can better catch the attention and interest of young learners, resulting in superior academic outcomes.

Particularly in areas where cultural taboos and false information are prevalent, menstrual education is still an important but frequently overlooked aspect of public health. For they provide a visually appealing and approachable means of distributing factual information and dismantling social barriers, comics have become a cutting-edge medium to address these issues.

Comics encourage healthy menstruation habits in addition to educating readers. Through entertaining and interesting content, *Menstrupedia* teaches young girls about good menstrual habits and shares factual information about the menstrual cycle. This method promotes improved cleanliness habits and helps to normalize menstruation, both of which are essential for avoiding infections and maintaining reproductive health.

The development of readers' empathy is another benefit of comics. By making important concepts about menstruation understandable and relevant, they contribute to normalizing the discussion of menstruation and provide young girls with the information they need to properly manage their menstrual health.

Conclusion

Menstrupedia is further expanding its reach through digital channels, with the goal of bridging the information gap in menstrual health education. Comic books have evolved as an extremely successful medium for menstrual education, capable of overcoming taboos, increasing understanding, and cultivating empathic awareness. Comics like *Menstrupedia* have successfully tackled the issues of menstruation stigma and ignorance by using compelling storytelling and visually appealing art. As digital platforms advance, comics' ability to reach and educate bigger audiences will only increase, making them an important tool in the ongoing battle to improve menstrual health education.

Comics play an important role in menstrual health education because they increase awareness, eliminate cultural barriers, and highlight the impact of menstruation on education and participation. It promotes comprehensive menstrual health policies and programs, promoting gender equality and enhancing the well-being of women and girls

around the world. *Menstrupedia* has proven to be an excellent tool for educating people about menstruation health by breaking down taboos, improving knowledge, and encouraging healthy practices.

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